

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

The Crisis of Authority

"The scholar according to the common people is whoever ascends the pulpit." The line is attributed to the Shafi'i polymath and reviver of his age al-Hafidh Jalal al-Din al-Suyuti. His words, may Allah have mercy on him, ring especially true now in an age when the call to return to "Qur'an and Sunnah alone" has become a fixture of religious discourse online. Who needs a madhhab, the reasoning goes, when the Qur'an and authentic hadith are more accessible than at any point in history? The sentiment is not new and untangling it fully is not my aim here. But it does raise a question worth sitting with, in a time that increasingly feels like a crisis of authority. What qualifies such a claim to legitimacy in the eyes of the layman? And where as an Ummah did we lose the thread such that those without the tools of Ijtihad, or independent legal reasoning, now speak with such confidence on matters well above their training?

Two answers seem worth pursuing. The first has to do with what Neil Postman called in his book *Amusing Ourselves to Death* "the medium as metaphor," a point I will pick up later. The second is simpler and more grim. Literacy, especially here in the United States, is collapsing. A recent YouGov poll found that four in ten Americans read no books at all in 2025, and that the median reader finished only two. In my own class at a local masjid of about 25 students, 23 said they had not read a book outside of assigned school reading in over a year! Set against that baseline, it is not hard to imagine how few people are willing to sit with a classical Islamic text, let alone its commentary, before rendering judgment on matters of the religion. Our tradition built on centuries of chains and patient study now competes with a culture that has largely lost the stamina to finish a single book.

I also want to point out that this medium is not neutral. This is essentially Postman's argument in *Amusing Ourselves to Death*. Television and social media bias runs toward the visual, the fast, and the entertaining. It has little patience for anything that asks a viewer to sit still and follow a chain of reasoning. A book I would recommend for anyone who wants to see this point made in full is *Four Arguments for the Elimination of Television* by Jerry Mander. Mander's argument written decades before social media existed was that the medium itself could not be reformed toward better content because the bias was built *into* the technology, not the content on it. Replace television with the feed and the argument only gets stronger. The most frustrating aspect of this is that feed does not even pretend to offer the settled programming schedule television once had.

This is how the pulpit al-Suyuti warned about gets rebuilt in digital form. The pulpit is now a feed or platform and anyone can climb it. The scholarly qualification the layman once deferred to, years spent with a teacher, memorizing a matn, and defending a reading in front of someone who could correct you is completely invisible online. What we can see today is confidence,

production value, and the ability to fit a position into something shareable. None of that has anything to do with whether the position is sound. All of it has to do with whether it spreads and garners enough attention by algorithms that decide what the rest of us see.

There is no single fix for a loss this large and I won't pretend to offer one. But a few things seem like a reasonable place to begin. These include but are certainly not limited to studying the traditional sciences with people actually qualified and vetted to teach them, reading enough books and articles to rebuild the stamina the tradition assumes, asking questions instead of settling for the first confident answer, and simply spending less time on the platforms built to reward speed over soundness. None of this restores the thread on its own, but I sincerely hope that this is a positive first step to set a precedent for the rest to follow slowly.

Perhaps the deeper remedy is not just what we consume but what we resist. Imam Abu al-Hasan al-Shadhili eloquently said:

“Knock on the door of the Dhikr seeking shelter with Allah and avowing your need of Him with continual silence toward your fellows and the shepherding of your innermost being to guard it from conversing with the lower self with every breath, if you desire to have spiritual sufficiency.”

And Allah knows best.